

# Technocratic backlash and the data center war

## TREND 3 | US South

### Abstract

The populations of the Americas and Western Europe are becoming increasingly hostile to what feels like a runaway unaccountable tech industry. Poor behavior by tech investors have soured people to tech firms and have made them suspicious of their intentions. The most broad-coalition consensus is that data-centers and battery production facilities are undesirable. In every area news can be found of hastily planned data center builds that are wildly unpopular due to their disregard of their effects on the communities around them and occasional outright fraud or regulatory breaches committed by these firms.

### Localized incarnations

#### Grassroots rejection of data centers

In every metro Atlanta county there are currently planned data centers and intense fighting against them. Atlanta has quick access to many of the necessary natural and logistical infrastructure necessary for these data centers. Residents are finding out data centers make bad neighbors; they are hot, creating microclimates around them, strain the power grid, strain the water table, and provide only a tiny amount permanent jobs, and due to tax deals contribute very little to the local tax base.

#### Examples:

proposed \$5 billion Rivian factory near Atlanta has faced intense local resistance, stalling, and legal battles, resulting in a paused project after over \$200 million in state funds were already spent on site preparation. Residents cite environmental concerns (groundwater impact), disruption of rural character, and lack of transparency.

DeKalb County (Ellenwood): Residents and activists have protested a proposed 1-million-square-foot data center, raising alarms about environmental impact and high-volume water usage. A "pause" on new data center developments was extended until June 23, 2026, to evaluate these impacts.

Southwest Atlanta: In April 2026, a community meeting led to a 105–87 vote rejecting a proposed data center, with residents citing concerns over the strain on resources and a desire for community-focused development rather than industrial expansion.

#### Tech misbehavior souring public trust

Over the last decade there have been countless public scandals at the conduct of developers; from shady land swaps, misappropriated public funding, outright knowingly breaching environmental protections, and innumerable accusations of fraud and corruption. Trust in tech firms and especially private equity has cratered.

#### Examples:

DeKalb County exchanged 40 acres of Intrenchment Creek Park (ICP) for 53 acres of land owned by then-Blackhall Studios (now Shadowbox Studios) owner Ryan Millsap. Failed Promises: The developer failed to complete the promised expansion of the movie studio and did not deliver on promised workforce development or specific park improvements (\$1.5 million) to the new location. Data Center Threat: Reports suggest the exchanged parkland is being considered for a data center development rather than the promised studio expansion.

QTS campus, managed by Blackstone, used 29+ million gallons over a period of 4 to 15 months, according to differing reports. The Cause: Two industrial-scale water hookups were discovered; one was installed without utility knowledge, and the other was not linked to the company’s billing account.

### Business and design implications

#### Reputation and trust rehab

For firms that want to maintain a sustainable relationship with the public and with their customers, tech and development firms must engage in conspicuous transparency and adherence to ecological and tax regulations.

#### Clear and cogent messaging

It is critical at this moment for firms to make public, clear, and cogent arguments for the necessity of their resource consumption. It will no longer be enough to say, “we need it for progress.” They must explain what the end goal of the progress is and how it will benefit the public good.

#### Design by collaboration

Design methodologies must focus on intense and direct collaboration with the public and the end consumer. The design language needs to be a dialog between organization and the public. Design aesthetics and tone should be less sleek and polished, it should show humanity, and it should include idiosyncrasies and “mistakes.”